



Photograph Jiten Gandhi Imaging Atul Deshmukh

All-A-Board!

Budget motherboards aren't the el cheapo items they used to be. Here's a shootout of all the 'budget' boards out there for the cost-conscious

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A computer for Rs 10,000 is still a dream that will take some time in coming to fruition, but there is absolutely no denying that prices of computer components have literally crashed from the exorbitant rates that were being charged some years ago.

Today, you can buy a decent system that will let you run all your office applications and let you browse the Internet, as well as indulge in moderate gaming, for roughly Rs 25,000. We take a look here at budget (within and around Rs 5,000) motherboards, one of the most significant contributors to PC cost.

It is generally seen that falling prices lead to cutting of

corners and a deterioration in the overall quality of the product. The case is slightly different here—all the motherboards we tested, though cheap, were absolutely crammed with features that would give more expensive motherboards a run for their money!

The Groups

We divided the motherboards we received on the basis of the platform they supported (AMD and Intel).

The AMD boards were further divided into those with onboard graphics and those without. This wasn't required for the Intel boards, as all Intel boards (barring the Foxconn 915PL7AE-8S, which is mentioned in a separate box in this article) came with onboard graphics.

THE AMD MOTHERBOARDS

AMD has four chipset manufacturers—ATi, nVidia, SiS and Via—that create motherboard chipsets for it. This obviously leads to a variety of boards with large variances in performance.

Features

In terms of features, the boards were so varied that we had a difficult time grouping them. Some used the 939 socket, others used 754; then some had an AGP port, others had PCI Express (PCIe); but a lot of features were common and can now be taken as standard feature set even though they seemed rather high end a few months ago.

As these are entry-level motherboards, we weren't really expecting too much, but half